



E-LEARNING UNIT

# Children and Armed Conflict

A child-specific framework within comprehensive Protection of Civilians

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Audience: Child protection & POC practitioners

Duration: 10–15 minutes

# What you will be able to do

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01

## Distinguish the two agendas

Differentiate the Children and Armed Conflict (CAAC) agenda from the broader Protection of Civilians (POC) mandate, and explain where they overlap and diverge.

02

## know the six grave violations

Identify the six grave violations as monitoring and accountability categories, not the full universe of harm, and weigh their operational implications.

03

## Apply a POC lens to child risk

Trace a threat pattern from civilian harm to child-specific impact, and select appropriate prevention, response, and accountability levers.

# Who is a child?

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## Art. 1 - Convention on the Rights of the Child

A child means every human being below the age of eighteen years,  
unless under the law applicable to the child, majority is attained  
earlier

# Children are civilians – and more

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## The comprehensive POC agenda

- Physical protection from the effects of hostilities
- Safe, unimpeded humanitarian access & assistance
- Prevention of forced displacement & return
- Respect for IHL, human rights & refugee law
- Accountability for violations and remedy

## The CAAC child-specific layer

- Recruitment & use by armed forces/groups
- Abduction, separation & unaccompanied minors
- Conflict-related sexual violence (CRSV)
- Attacks on schools, hospitals & protected objects
- Denial of humanitarian access for children

PLUS age-specific harms

### Key point

CAAC is not a parallel humanitarian niche. It is a child-specific accountability and protection framework that operates inside and strengthens comprehensive POC.

# A record year, and a shifting perpetrator pattern

38,558

verified grave violations  
against children

24,174

children directly affected &  
rights violated

*3,176 subjected to multiple  
violations*

1 in 3

victims were girls

34%

rise in child-killing incidents  
vs. 2024

*mostly from explosive remnants*

**For the first time since the mandate began, 30 years ago, government forces were the leading perpetrators of grave violations against children — against a backdrop of explosive weapons in populated areas and AI-integrated targeting processes.**

Highest-burden situations: Occupied Palestinian Territory & Israel, DRC, Nigeria, Myanmar, Somalia. 13,112 children received reintegration support; 40 commitments taken by parties to conflict.

# The normative architecture

## INTERNATIONAL LAW

### Geneva Conventions & APs

Civilian & child protection in IAC/NIAC

### CRC (1989) + OPAC (2000)

Under-18s & direct participation in hostilities

### 1951 Refugee Convention

Refugee & IDP protection principles

## UN SECURITY COUNCIL

### Res. 1261 (1999)

First CAAC resolution; sets the agenda

### Res. 1612 (2005)

Establishes the Monitoring and Reporting Mechanism (MRM) & Working Group

### Res. 1882 / 1998 / 2225

Expand triggers: killing, rape, attacks on schools, abduction

## SOFT-LAW & POLITICAL COMMITMENTS

### Paris Principles (2007)

Disarmament, Demobilization & Reintegration (DDR) of children associated with armed forces/groups

### Safe Schools Declaration (2015)

Protect education from attack

### Vancouver Principles (2017)

Child protection in peacekeeping

# The six grave violations

## 01 Killing & maiming

6,266 killed / 7,958 maimed

## 02 Recruitment & use

6,607 children affected

## 03 Abduction

5,129 children abducted

## 04 Rape & sexual violence

ongoing, widely under-reported

## 05 Attacks on schools & hospitals

protected objects targeted

## 06 Denial of humanitarian access

8,322 incidents

### Caution

These six categories anchor the Monitoring and Reporting Mechanism and trigger listing in the Secretary-General's annual report. They are accountability triggers but not a comprehensive list of the harms children suffer. Family separation, disability, trauma, and education loss are real harms that may fall outside the six.

# THE MONITORING AND REPORTING MECHANISM (MRM)

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## MRM

- The MRM is put in place in a country once a party to a conflict in that country is listed in the annexes to the Secretary-General's annual report on CAAC.

## Country Task Force for Monitoring and Reporting (CTFMR)

- The Country Task Force for Monitoring and Reporting (CTFMR) is the organizational structure for the implementation of the MRM at the country level
- Once the MRM is established all parties to conflict (state armed forces, armed groups, paramilitaries) are monitored.

### Caution

The number of verified violations reported is just the tip of the iceberg. Many challenges like the access to affected areas to collect and verify information and systematic **under-reporting** remain.

# Linking CAAC to comprehensive POC

| Threat pattern                                                       | Child-specific impact                        | Strategic response                                                                                       | Operational child protection                                   |
|----------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Explosive weapons in populated areas (EWIPA)</b>                  | Death, maiming, disability                   | Advocacy on International Humanitarian Law (IHL) enforcement & promoting the EWIPA Political Declaration | Case management, family tracing, reunification rehabilitation  |
| <b>Armed actor presence near schools</b>                             | (forced) recruitment, attacks on education   | Safe Schools Declaration; access                                                                         | Risk-informed education, (temporary) school relocation         |
| <b>Siege / access restrictions</b>                                   | Denial of humanitarian access                | Humanitarian access negotiation                                                                          | Child-focused relief convoys, nutrition/health screening       |
| <b>Conflict related sexual violence (CRSV) used as tactic of war</b> | Rape, abduction, severe trauma social stigma | Survivor-centred response and legal accountability                                                       | Psychological First Aid (PFA), medical/psychosocial, referrals |

# Operational response and safeguards

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## Monitoring & accountability

- MRM information management & verification standards
- Safe, confidential data handling & survivor consent
- Country task forces (CTFMRM)
- Action plans & engagement for de-listing

## Direct response services

- Case management & referral pathways
- Family tracing & reunification (FTR)
- Release & reintegration (DDR for children)
- Mental Health and Psychosocial Support (MHPSS)

## Cross-cutting safeguards

- Do-no-harm & conflict-sensitive analysis
- Survivor-centred CRSV response
- Risk-informed, disability-inclusive programming
- Treat children associated with parties primarily as victims

# QUIZ (1 of 2)

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- Q1** An armed group lists a 16-year-old courier as "support staff." Under OPAC/MRM this is:
- a) Not a violation; non-combat roles exempt
  - b) Grave violation; recruitment & use
  - c) Only if the child fired a weapon
  - d) HR concern, not CAAC
- Q2** A donor asks to publish verified MRM data naming a party in a public report. Best response:
- a) Publish; naming is the MRM's purpose
  - b) Decline; MRM is for SG report & engagement
  - c) Publish only children's names
  - d) Publish after deleting metadata
- Q3** Which UNSC resolution established the MRM and the CAAC Working Group?
- a) 1261 (1999)
  - b) 1612 (2005)
  - c) 1998 (2011)
  - d) 2225 (2015)
- Q4** Which is NOT one of the six grave violations?
- a) Attacks on schools/hospitals
  - b) Denial of humanitarian access
  - c) Family separation
  - d) Abduction
- Q5** A 15-year-old detained for association with a group. Under OPAC/Paris Principles:
- a) Treat as security threat; prosecute
  - b) Treat as victim; reintegrate; detention last resort
  - c) Hold for intelligence extraction
  - d) Return to the armed group

## QUIZ (2 of 2)

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**Q6** Which pairing correctly matches a UN Grave Violation with a corresponding POC Framework?

- a) Family separation → case management
- b) Attacks on schools → Safe Schools Declaration
- c) Trauma → Mental Health and Psychosocial Support (MHPSS)
- d) Poverty → cash assistance

**Q7** In 2025, most child casualties in conflict zones resulted from:

- a) Small-arms fire
- b) Explosive ordnance
- c) Disease
- d) Displacement

**Q8** In the Paris Principles, "DDR" refers to children's:

- a) Detection & Documentation of Recruitment
- b) Disarmament, Demobilization & Reintegration
- c) Diplomatic, Development & Recovery
- d) Data, Documentation & Reporting

**Q9** Which is a political commitment to protect education from attack?

- a) CRC
- b) OPAC
- c) Safe Schools Declaration
- d) Geneva Conventions

**Q10** What is the primary role of the Monitoring and Reporting Mechanism (MRM) established under UN Security Council Resolution 1612 regarding children and armed conflict?

- a) To directly arrest and prosecute military commanders who commit human rights violations against children.
- b) To deploy international peacekeeping forces specifically tasked with guarding schools in active war zones.
- c) To systematically collect, verify, and report timely information on six grave violations against children in situations of armed conflict.
- d) To manage child refugee camps and distribute direct humanitarian financial aid to affected families.

# Three things to carry forward

CAAC is a child-specific accountability and protection framework operating inside — not parallel to — comprehensive POC.

The six grave violations are MRM triggers and listing criteria, not the full universe of harm; keep monitoring and programming distinct but linked.

Sound CP action is risk-informed, survivor-centred, do-no-harm, and tied to civilian-harm mitigation, access, and accountability.

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## Further resources

- > [UN Office of the SRSG on CAAC](#)
- > [UN OCHA — Protection of Civilians](#)
- > [Global Coalition to Protect Education from Attack](#)
- > [UN SG Annual Report on CAAC \(2025\)](#)
- > [ICRC — IHL & children](#)
- > [The Alliance for Child Protection in Humanitarian Action](#)